

Fate's Edge

Essential Starting Guide

GM & Player Reference — One Region, One Road

“The road is a ledger. Every broken wheel is a debt, every lit lamp a witness. The only question is: what are you willing to owe?”
— *Dusana of the Raven Road*

Welcome to Fate's Edge. This guide contains everything you need to start playing—core rules, character creation, one region (Acasia), GM procedures, and a starter adventure hook. No other books required.

1 The Philosophy of Consequence

1.1 Narrative First

Every roll tells a story. In Fate's Edge, mechanics serve the story, not the other way around. When you roll dice, you are not asking “did I succeed?”—you are asking “what happens next?”

The Golden Rule: When in doubt, make the choice that serves the story. Set DV=3, Position=Controlled, and let the dice fall.

1.2 Safety at the Table

Fate's Edge explores mature themes. Use these tools to keep play safe:

- **X-Card:** Any player may say “X” to stop a scene. No questions asked.
- **Lines:** Content that will not appear (e.g., “no harm to children”).
- **Veils:** Content that fades to black (e.g., “romance is implied, not described”).

Establish these in Session Zero.

2 The Core Resolution

2.1 The 90-Second Loop

Every meaningful action follows this cycle:

1. **Declare** your intent and approach (Attribute + Skill).
2. **GM sets DV** (2–5+) and **Position** (Dominant/Controlled/Desperate).
3. **Roll** dice pool (Attribute + Skill d10s).
4. **Count successes** (6–10 = 1 success). Each 1 = Story Beat (SB) for GM.
5. **Apply outcome** using the Outcome Matrix.
6. **GM spends SB** to introduce complications.

2.2 Difficulty Value (DV)

Difficulty Values	
DV	When to Use
2	Routine – clear path, no pressure
3	Pressured – mild opposition (default)
4	Hard – serious resistance
5+	Extreme – dramatic gamble

Default DV is 3. Do not inflate DVs to “challenge” players—use Position instead.

2.3 Position

Position tells you how risky the action is and changes how dice behave:

Position Effects		
Position	Frame	Mechanical Effect
Dominant	You press advance	Re-roll one failure
Controlled	Balanced norm	No re-rolls
Desperate	Act under duress	Re-roll one success

Pro tip: Spend 1 Boon to improve Position by one step before rolling.

2.4 The Outcome Matrix

Outcome Matrix	
Roll Result	What Happens
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB = 0	Clean Success – Intent achieved, no complication.
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB > 0	Success with SB – Intent achieved; GM spends SB.
0 < Successes < DV	Partial – Progress; gain 1 Boon.
Successes = 0	Miss – No progress; gain 2 Boons; GM spends SB.

A Partial is not failure. It moves the story forward: improve Position for next attempt, reduce DV, succeed at reduced scale, or reveal information.

A Miss is never “nothing happens.” The GM must introduce a complication.

2.5 Critical Success (10s)

A roll of 10 counts as **two successes**. If the overall roll succeeds:

- **1 ten:** Strong success—improve Position or gain minor advantage.
- **2 tens:** Exceptional—choose two benefits.
- **3+ tens:** Legendary—decisive victory; clear 1 segment from a relevant clock.

3 Resources: Boons & Story Beats

3.1 Boons—Player Currency

Boons represent luck, momentum, and narrative leverage. **Spend them freely.**

Boons at a Glance			
Earning Boons		Gain	
Spending Boons			
Partial success	Gain 1	Re-roll a die (1 Boon)	
Miss	Gain 2	Improve Position	(1 Boon)
Bond-driven action	Gain 1	Activate Asset (1 Boon) (once/bond/session)	
GM award	+1 (rare)	Convert 2	→ 1 XP (once/session)

Holding cap: 5 Boons. At end of scene, reduce to 2 (excess lost).

The Math of Fun: Hoarding Boons for XP conversion starves the table of drama. A re-rolled failure or an improved Position creates a memorable moment. Spend Boons!

3.2 Story Beats (SB)—GM Currency

Every time a player rolls a 1, the GM gains Story Beats. Spend SB to introduce complications:

SB Spend Menu	
Cost	Complication
1 SB	Minor – noise, distraction, tick a clock +1
2 SB	Moderate – alarm raised, lose advantage, worsen Position
3+ SB	Major – reinforcements, scene shifts, break an asset

Be aggressive with SB. Unused pressure is wasted momentum.

4 Injury & Exhaustion

4.1 Fatigue—The Weight of the World

Each point of Fatigue worsens your Position. If already Desperate, each Fatigue imposes –1 die instead.

Fatigue Progression	
Fatigue Level	Effect
1	Position worsens one step
2	If already Desperate, –1 die; otherwise Position worsens
3	–2 dice (if already Desperate from Fatigue)
4+	Collapse, KO, incapacitated

Recovery: Short rest removes 2 Fatigue; full night's rest removes all.

4.2 Harm—Serious Injury

Harm Levels	
Harm Level	Effect
Harm 1	–1 die on related actions
Harm 2	–1 dice on most actions
Harm 3	Incapacitated or dying

4.3 The Roller-Coaster Effect

Taking Harm clears Fatigue. The shock of a wound resets your exhaustion. This creates dramatic swings—a character near collapse who takes a wound and finds a second wind.

4.4 Armor Conversion

When you take Harm, armor converts some to Fatigue:

Armor Conversion				
Armor	Harm 1	Harm 2	Harm 3	
Light	Fatigue 1	Harm 1	+ Harm 2	+
		Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	
Medium	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Harm 2	+
			Fatigue 1	
Heavy	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 2	

5 Building Your Character

5.1 10-Minute Checklist

Start with **30 XP** (max 34 with Bonds/Complications).

- 1. **Concept:** One sentence (origin, profession, defining trait).
- 2. **Attributes (1–5):** Spend XP—primary to 3 (9 XP), secondaries to 2 (6 XP each).
- 3. **Skills (0–5):** Spend 8–12 XP on key skills.
- 4. **Talents:** 1–3 talents (2–6 XP each).
- 5. **Patron (optional):** Choose a Patron for magic.
- 6. **Assets/Followers (optional):** Minor Asset (4 XP) or follower (Cap² XP).
- 7. **Bonds & Complications:** Up to +4 XP total.

5.2 Attributes

Attributes		
Attribute	What It Does	Example Skills
Body	Strength, agility, endurance	Melee, Athletics, Stealth
Wits	Perception, quick thinking	Insight, Lore, Investigation
Spirit	Willpower, intuition	Arcana, Resolve, Survival
Presence	Charisma, leadership	Sway, Command, Deception

Cost to raise: New rating × 3 XP. Downtime = new rating in days.

5.3 Skills

Cost to raise: New level × 2 XP. Downtime = new level in days.

Core Skills		
Combat	Physical	Social
Melee	Athletics	Sway
Ranged	Stealth	Command
Brawl	Endurance	Deception
Tactics	Craft	Performance
	Survival	Insight
Knowledge	Magic	
Lore	Arcana	
Investigation	Ritual	
Medicine		

5.4 Sample Starting Build—The Duelist (30 XP)

- **Attributes:** Body 3 (15 XP), Wits 2 (6 XP)
- **Skills:** Melee 2 (6 XP), Athletics 1 (2 XP)
- **Talent:** Keen Senses (2 XP)
- **Total:** 31 XP (bank 1)

6 The Known World: Acasia

“The Broken Province”

6.1 Genre & Mood

Low fantasy / mercenary realism / border feud. Acasia is a former province of the Utaran Empire that festers in the space between famine and ambition. Every hill wears a crown, every bridge demands a price, and every road curves back to the same cursed crossroads.

6.2 What You Notice First

The smell of mildew on old parchment and wet ash. The way every milestone has been recarved. The silence of a village that heard you coming and chose not to open its gates.

6.3 The One Rule That Kills Newcomers

Never sign a contract on a bridge. The river is a witness, and it never forgets a signature.

6.4 Key Factions

Acasia Factions		
Faction	Leader	Goal
Broken March	Mar-gravine Mira	Keep province from fracturing
Lame King's Claimants	Oren "Tin Crown"	Be recognised as true sovereign
Free Companies	Various captains	Find permanent contracts
Blackwood Matriarchs	Hedge-witches	Survive the Curse

6.5 The Curse of Acasia

The land remembers what we did—and what we failed to do. Every broken milestone is a forgotten promise. Every abandoned vineyard is a harvest we chose not to plant. **Mechanical effect:** When crossing a bridge or crossroads, roll Spirit + Resolve (DV 3). On a failure, the Curse stirs—gain 1 Fatigue or a minor complication (GM's choice).

6.6 Acasia Mini-Generator (d6)

1. A bridge toll has tripled overnight; the toll-keeper is a deserter from your old company.
2. A hedge-witch offers to break your blood-debt—for the memory of your first kill.
3. The Lame King travels with a mute jester who writes prophecies on fallen leaves.
4. Bandits stole a Blackwood Matriarch's curse-box. Recover it before it opens.

5. A free company captain wants to hire you—but their last three hires died of “accidents.”
6. The Margravine’s seal is missing. Whoever finds it can rewrite border law.

7 Running Fate’s Edge

7.1 The GM Mindset

You are not a referee or a narrator robot. You are a **co-creator of drama**. Your tools (SB, clocks) are not punishments—they are how you play the game. When you spend a Story Beat to tick a clock, you are making a move. Enjoy it.

7.2 Your Defaults

When in doubt:

- **DV: 3**
- **Position: Controlled**
- **Consequence:** Fatigue, time pressure, or exposure
- **Clocks:** One short clock tied to the scene

7.3 What You Are Doing

- Stating Position clearly and confidently
- Letting partials move the story forward
- Spending Story Beats to make failure interesting
- Allowing success to create new problems

7.4 The Three-Clock Guideline

Keep 1–3 active clocks per scene:

Clock Sizes	
Segments	When to Use
4	Short, straightforward challenge
6	Standard scene or tension
8	Extended or complex problem
10	Epic or campaign-long pressure

7.5 GM Survival Tips

7.5.1 When Players Go Off the Rails

Do not panic. Ask: “*What is your goal?*” Name the simplest obstacle—then set Position and DV.

7.5.2 When Players Hoard Boons

Remind them: “*Boons are not XP tokens—they are dramatic fuel.*” Introduce time pressure that forces spending.

7.5.3 When a Scene Stalls

- Ask a leading question: “*What are you afraid of here?*”
- Tick a clock: “*While you argue, the fire spreads—Collapse [4] advances 1.*”
- Cut to another player.

7.5.4 When You Don’t Know a Rule

Make a ruling that keeps the story moving. Default to DV 3, Controlled Position. Look it up later.

8 The Lantern at Dusk

A Starter Adventure in Acasia

8.1 Setup

The party is hired by **Elder Sarai** of the remote village of Duskwood. A terrible blight is spreading from the old barrow in the hills—the same barrow where a cursed lantern was buried centuries ago. The lantern must be brought to a stone circle in the valley to break the curse.

8.2 What the Party Knows

- The lantern is in the central chamber of the barrow.
- The barrow is guarded by restless spirits (the Duskwights).
- A rival treasure hunter, **Quick Lena**, has also entered the barrow.
- The curse will kill the village’s crops in three days.

8.3 Clocks

Adventure Clocks	
Clock	Effect
Barrow	Col- Ticks on failure inside. At 6, entrance seals.
Lena’s Agenda	Ticks each scene inside. At 4, Lena takes lantern first.

8.4 Scenes

8.4.1 Scene 1—The Entry (DV 3, Controlled)

Obstacle: Cave-in blocks the way (Body + Athletics). **Partial:** Tick Barrow Collapse +1. **Miss:** Mark Harm 1, tick Collapse +1.

8.4.2 Scene 2—The Spirit Corridor (DV 3, Controlled)

Three Duskwrights demand an offering (a memory or a secret). Roll Presence + Sway. **Partial:** They also steal random equipment. **Miss:** They attack (Cap 2, Harm 1 each).

8.4.3 Scene 3—The Lantern Chamber

Quick Lena is trying to pry the lantern loose. Confront her: Presence + Sway (DV 3, Controlled). **Partial:** She agrees to split the reward but demands a favor later (start Debt Clock [4]). **Miss:** She triggers a trap—tick Collapse +2.

8.4.4 Scene 4—Escape (Skill Challenge)

The party needs **3 successes before 2 failures** to escape. Each PC describes their approach. DV 3, Position Desperate. Each failure ticks Collapse +1.

8.5 Resolution

Return the lantern to the stone circle. Break the curse with Spirit + Lore (DV 2). **Partial:** Curse lifts, but lantern attracts another danger soon. **Miss:** Curse pushed back one year; a dark spirit escapes.

8.6 Advancement

Each PC earns **6–10 XP** at the end.

9 Basic Magic

9.1 The Five Paths (Quick Reference)

Magic Paths

Path	Complexity	Cost	Type	Best For
Runkeeper	Low	Obligation		First-timers, reliable casters
Cantor	Medium	Corruption		Bards, risk-takers
Invoker	Medium	Obligation time		+ Ritual specialists
Summoner	High	Leash Boons		+ Pet-class fans
Free Caster	High	Backlash		Improv players

For first magical characters, play a Runkeeper.

9.2 Runkeeper—The Reliable Path

Requirements: Familiar (Thiasos, 2 XP) + Codex (4 XP) + Patron.

Invoking a Rite: 1 action. Mark +1 Obligation. Effect works as written.

Push It: Once per scene, mark +1 Obligation to amplify (+1 die or +1 Effect).

Obligation Capacity: Spirit + Presence. Exceeding capacity: 1 Fatigue per segment.

9.3 Sample—The Traveler's Runkeeper

Kestra, Traveler's Runkeeper (34 XP)

- Spirit 3 (9 XP), Wits 2 (6 XP)
- Lore 2 (6 XP), Insight 1 (2 XP), Sway 1 (2 XP)
- Talents: Familiar (2 XP), Codex (4 XP)
- Rites: Road-Sense (4 XP), Traveler's Boon (5 XP)
- Obligation Capacity: 4 (Spirit 3 + Presence 1)

9.4 Free Casting—The TAGS System

For improvisational magic, construct spells using TAGS:

$$DV = 1 + \text{number of TAGS}$$

Dangerous TAGS (Leap, Fold, Gate, Transform, Dominate) add +2 DV.

9.4.1 Example Spells

- **Light [Illuminate]** – DV 2. Create small, sustained light.

- **HEAL** [HEAL] – DV 2. Remove 1 Fatigue from self or touched ally.
- **Shield of Air** [WARD] [DEFEND] – DV 3. Gain Position +1 on next defense.
- **Flame Cloak** [BURNING] [AREA] – DV 3. Enemies suffer –1 die to approach.

Backlash: On a Miss or when GM spends SB, magic backfires—Fatigue 1, Harm 1, or a thematic complication.

10 Advancement & XP

10.1 Earning XP (Per Session)

XP Breakdown	
Achievement	XP
Attendance	+2
Major objectives	+2–4
Discoveries	+1–2
Hard choices	+1–2
Story engagement	+1–3
Personal goals	+1–2

Game pace options: Gritty (4–6 XP/session), Standard (6–10), Epic (10–14).

10.2 Spending XP

XP Costs		
Improvement	XP Cost	Downtime
Attribute increase	New rating × 3	New rating in days
Skill increase	New level × 2	New level in days
Minor Asset	4 XP	1 day
Standard Asset	8 XP	1 week
Major Asset	12 XP	1 month
Minor Talent	2–4 XP	3–10 days
Major Talent	5–8 XP	1–2 weeks

10.3 Tiers of Play

Character Tiers		
Tier	XP Range	Reputation
I: Novice	0–40	Local
II: Seasoned	41–90	Regional
III: Veteran	91–150	National
IV: Paragon	151–220	Continental
V: Mythic	221+	Legendary

11 Quick Reference Tables

11.1 Combat in Brief

- **Turn:** 1 Action + 1 Move
- **Move:** Shift one range band (Close ↔ Near ↔ Far)
- **Opportunity Attack:** Leaving Close range without Disengage provokes one free melee attack.
- **Sidestep Strike:** Move one band as part of melee attack; worsen Position by one step.

11.2 Weapon Modifiers

Melee Weapons		
Weight Notes	Close	Near
Light	+2d	+1d
Quick in tight quarters		
Medium	+1d	+2d
Set once/scene or –1d first attack		
Heavy	–1d	+3d
Set once/scene or –2d first attack		

11.3 Range Bands

- **Close:** Touching distance—grapples, knife-work
- **Near:** Same room/area—a rush away
- **Far:** Same site but distant—requires route or time
- **Absent:** Off-screen—requires scene change

11.4 Skill Synergies—Creative Pairs

Alternative Skill Pairs

Action	Standard Pair	Alternative Pair
Climbing	Body + Athletics	Wits + Athletics (clever route)
Persuading	Presence + Sway	Wits + Sway (logical argument)
Investigating	Wits + Investigation	Spirit + Investigation (intuitive leap)
Feinting	Wits + Melee	Presence + Melee (intimidation)

“The coin that never spends is the one you don’t remember taking.”

— Serafine of the Velvet Touch

Fate’s Edge Essential Guide — CC BY 4.0 — Nicholas A. Gasper

Set down in Castra Ferrum, Year of the Iron Harvest

11.5 Final GM Mantra

Set the DV low. Make the world react honestly. Let the pressure do the work. And remember—you are playing the game too.

12 Session Zero Checklist

Use this checklist to start your campaign.

1. **Lines & Veils** – What content is off-limits or only implied?
2. **Tone** – Cinematic action? Grim survival? Political intrigue? Dark horror?
3. **Campaign length** – One-shot, short arc (3-6 sessions), or long campaign (12+)?
4. **Character hooks** – Each player shares one goal and one fear.
5. **Patron interest** – Which Patrons (if any) are already watching the party?
6. **Starting situation** – Where does the story begin?
7. **House rules** – Any optional subsystems you plan to use?
8. **Scheduling & attendance** – How often do you meet? What if a player misses?
9. **Player-GM contract** – “We are co-creators, not adversaries.”
10. **Resource mindset** – “Boons are not XP tokens. Spend them. Embrace failure.”

“Now close the book—or keep reading. The road is waiting.”